

SHUTTERSTOCK

Holy Wheels

Two new train journeys aim to transport tourists to the realms of spirituality. Palace on Wheels (*above*), whose itinerary typically takes in Rajasthan and Agra, will ply a new route for the months of May and June, taking passengers from Delhi to Ayodhya, Prayagraj, Varanasi, Mathura and Vrindavan. No non-vegetarian fare or alcohol will be served on board and guests will be regaled with religious melodies throughout. Meanwhile, Uttarakhand has announced the rather more budget-friendly Manaskhand Express tourist train, set to operate from April, which will spotlight lesser-known destinations in the hill state. The train will run from Kolkata to Kathgodam, from where passengers will be taken by road to destinations like Purnagiri, Hat Kalika, Patal Bhuvaneshwar, Baleshwar, Jageshwar, Kasar Devi, Nanakmatta Gurudwara, and so on.

CRUISE CONTROL

Antara River Cruises—the same folks who started the world's longest river cruise in 2023—have launched Antara Catamarans, to traverse the Bhitarkanika mangrove wetland in Odisha, also known as the mini-Amazon of India. Two catamarans, MV *Mahanadi* and MV *Bhitarkanika*, have been launched, and both are two-suite, state-of-the-art, sustainably built vessels. The catamarans are capable of travelling at 5 knots per hour, and are designed specifically to explore the Bhitarkanika wetland. They are also India's first hybrid solar electric and fuel-powered cruises.

3N/ 4D itineraries are on offer and the cruise is priced at Rs 25,000 per person per night on double occupancy. See *antaracruises.com*.



